

Session 5: Design of Ephesians 1-3

Key Takeaways

- The first three chapters of Ephesians are designed symmetrically so that the reader will compare and contrast the corresponding sections.
- The center of this symmetrical design is about the new temple made from a unified people with Jesus as the cornerstone.
- To comprehend the revelation of Jesus is to undergo an experience of worship.
- Paul draws attention to his imprisonment because the lowest status is the highest honor in the Upside-Down Kingdom of Jesus.

Literary Design of Ephesians

The letter is designed with two large movements, each with a corresponding introductory and concluding section.

Movement 1: Chapters 1-3

A	1:1-14 Victory song to the Father, Son, and Spirit		
	B	1:15-21 Prayer for an apocalypse of power	
		C	2:1-10 Rescued from death and the Ruler of the age 2:11-18 Rescued from hostility and alienation from God's family
			D 2:19-22 The Messianic victory monument: the new temple
		C'	3:1-13 The imprisoned apostle of the messianic apocalypse
	B'	3:14-19 Prayer for power to grasp the Messiah's love	
A'	3:20-21 Doxology song to the Father and to the Son		
The Design of Ephesians 1-3. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ephesians (2019).			

A and A': Praise

This section opens and closes with poetic hymns of praise ([Eph. 1:1-14](#), [3:20-21](#)), honoring God for revealing his purpose for all creation through Jesus' life, death, and resurrection.

B and B': Prayers

Inside of these are two corresponding prayers for a revelation of knowledge and power ([Eph. 1:15-21](#), [3:14-19](#)) for God's people.

C and C': New Exodus

These are two contrasting expositions of the new Exodus. Ephesians 2:1-18 has two parallel panels retelling God's liberation of enslaved people ([Eph. 2:1-10](#)) who were separated from God's covenant family of Israel ([Eph. 2:11-18](#)). Each panel resolves in a celebration of their resurrection and incorporation into the new humanity. The corresponding section is Paul's own story ([Eph. 3:1-13](#)) of becoming a herald of the message in Ephesians 2:1-18, which has made him a "prisoner of the Messiah."

D: Victory of the Messiah

At the center of this rhetorical unit (and the climax of Eph. 2:11-18 as a whole) is the creation of the new messianic humanity, which is the new temple anticipated by the Hebrew Prophets and Jesus himself ([Eph. 2:19-22](#)).

Movement 2: Chapters 4-6

A	4:1-16 Promoting the unity of the new humanity
	B 4:17-5:2 The old versus the new
	B' 5:3-14 The light versus the dark
	B'' 5:15-6:9 The foolish versus the wise, Spirit-influenced humanity
A'	6:10-20 The battle for the unity of the new humanity

The Design of Ephesians 4-6. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ephesians (2019).

A and A': New Humanity

These sections correspond in that Ephesians 4:1-16 brings the "unified new humanity" theme of chapters 1-3 to a climactic summary and portrays the Messiah's body as a "mature man" who can stand firm against the "schemes" (*μεθοδεῖα* [Eph. 4:14](#), [6:11](#)) of hostile forces. This matches [Ephesians 6:10-20](#), which portrays the

Messiah's body as a warrior who dons the metaphorical armor of the divine warrior in order to protect their unity and stand firm.

B and B' and B'': Contrasts

These diverse sections each have a contrast between the old humanity and the new, explored from different angles. This contrasting "You are A so don't live like Z" pervades each of these units.

Outline of Ephesians

The Gospel and the New Humanity (1:1-3:21)

1. Prologue (1:1-2)
2. A New Song for a New Exodus (1:3-14)
3. A Prayer for Revelation and Resurrection Power (1:15-23)
4. From Living Dead to Membership in the Messianic Temple (2:1-22)
 - a. From Living Death to New Creation (2:1-10)
 - b. From Hostile Outsiders to New Humanity (2:11-22)
5. The Mystery of the New Creation Family (3:1-13)
6. A Prayer for Love Among God's Family (3:14-21)

The Unity and Family Ethic of the New Humanity (4:1-6:24)

1. The Unity of the New Humanity (4:1-16)
2. The Family Ethic of the New Humanity (4:17-5:2)
3. Living in Light, Leaving the Dark (5:3-14)
4. The Spirit-Empowered Life of God's Family (5:15-6:9)
 - a. Living Wisely ... (5:15-17)
 - b. ... By the Power of the Spirit (5:18-21)
 - c. The Spirit-Empowered Household (5:22-6:9)
 - i. Wives and Husbands (5:22-33)
 - ii. Parents and Children (6:1-4)
 - iii. Slaves and Masters (6:5-9)
5. The Spiritual War of the Messianic Family (6:10-20)
6. Conclusion (6:21-24)

Prologue: Translation and Literary Design of Ephesians 1:1-2

¹ Paul
an apostle of Messiah Jesus
through the will of God,
to the holy ones
who [are in Ephesus]
also are believing in Messiah Jesus,
² grace to y'all and peace
from God our Father
and the Lord Jesus Messiah.

Ephesians 1:1-2. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ephesians (2019).

Reflection Question

Summarize the logical flow of Ephesians 1-3 as best as you can.